

CHAPTER 1

The Clo

Pip the mouse lived in a flour tin behind the oven of Mrs. Pell's bakery.

Every morning the shop smelled like sugar and warm bread. Every night the lights went off, the Closed sign flipped, and the little bell on the door went quiet.

Pip was not supposed to talk where people could hear. Mrs. Pell was kind, but she believed mice belonged in stories, not in her cupcakes.

Pip's best friend was Dot, a sparrow who slept on the bakery awning.

"The cinnamon buns are lonely," Pip whispered one evening, standing on the cooling rack.

"Buns cannot be lonely," Dot said. "They are buns."

"These ones can," Pip said. "They heard Mrs. Pell say she might close the shop. No one has bought the Friday pie in two weeks."

Dot ruffled her feathers. "Then we need a plan. Talking animals are good at plans."

From the drainpipe came a low voice.

"Plans get crumbs on the floor," said Captain Bean, an old ginger cat who pretended he did not work for the bakery. He did. He kept the night watch and stole exactly one pat of butter a week.

"If you two start a parade in here, I will have to look fierce."

"You look like a pillow," Pip said.

Captain Bean sniffed. "A fierce pillow."

CHAPTER 2

The Me

At midnight the bakery belonged to small feet.

Pip called a meeting in the biggest mixing bowl. Dot perched on the rim. Captain Bean sat on the floor and tried to look unimpressed. Two flour beetles named Tim and Tom arrived late and apologized to a spoon.

"Mrs. Pell is sad," Pip said. "Sad bakers forget to laugh. Forgotten laughs make dry cake."

"That is not science," said Tim.

"It is bakery science," said Pip.

Dot tapped the bowl with her beak. "People used to come for the Friday pie. We need them to remember why."

Captain Bean licked a paw. "People remember food that surprises them."

"Then we bake a surprise," Pip said.

The room went very still, which is hard in a room full of talking animals.

"Mice cannot use the big oven," Tom whispered. "The knobs are taller than a king."

"We can use the little toaster oven on the back counter," Dot said. "Mrs. Pell leaves it on warm for her tea bread."

Captain Bean stood up. "If anyone burns my butter, I resign."

CHAPTER 3

Stolen S

They worked like a tiny factory.

Pip measured sugar in a bottle cap. Dot fetched lemon peel from the compost pail. Tim and Tom rolled dough with a pencil. Captain Bean opened the toaster oven door with one dignified claw and looked both ways, as if the moon might tell on him.

The first tray came out too pale.

The second tray came out too dark.

The third tray came out golden, no bigger than buttons, smelling like lemon and brave decisions.

"What are they?" Dot asked.

Pip tasted one and closed his eyes. "Midnight buttons. Tiny lemon cookies. If a person eats one, they remember the first time they were happy in a bakery."

"That is a lot for a cookie," Captain Bean said. But he ate two.

Near dawn they left the cookies on a white plate by the register. Pip wrote a note in pencil, very small:

FROM FRIENDS OF THE SHOP

PLEASE

They hid. Mrs. Pell turned the key.

She saw the plate. She read the note. She sat down hard on her stool and laughed one surprised laugh, the kind that knocks flour off a sleeve.

"Well," she said to the empty shop. "I suppose I am not as alone as I thought."

CHAPTER 4

Friday P

Word travels faster than sparrows.

A boy bought three midnight buttons and told his sister. The sister told a bus driver. The bus driver told a whole bus. By Friday the line reached the lamppost.

Mrs. Pell baked the Friday pie again. She also baked a second plate of tiny lemon cookies and shook her head, smiling.

"I do not know which of you is helping me," she told the flour tin, the awning, and the cat on the windowsill. "But the shop stays open."

Pip almost cheered. Dot kicked him gently with a wing.

That night they held another meeting, this time with extra crumbs.

"We did it," Pip said.

"We did part of it," Captain Bean said. "Shops stay open when people come back tomorrow too."

Pip nodded. "Then we bake tomorrow too. Not too many. Just enough to keep the laugh in the cake."

Tim raised a beetle leg. "Can we name the cookies something less magical? My aunt worries."

"No," said Dot.

CHAPTER 5

The Mo

Saturday morning Mrs. Pell came in early.

Pip was still on the counter, dragging a bottle cap of sugar. He froze.

Mrs. Pell froze too.

They looked at each other. A mouse. A baker. A cap of sugar.

Mrs. Pell set down her keys very slowly.

"If I say you are a mouse who talks," she whispered, "I will have to explain you to the health inspector. If I say you are a dream, I can keep my shop and my Friday pie."

Pip's whiskers shook. "I can be a dream who measures carefully."

Mrs. Pell's mouth twitched. "Dreams should wash their feet."

She turned around and counted to twenty. When she turned back, Pip was gone. The bottle cap was rinsed. A single midnight button sat on the register, still warm.

Captain Bean, in the window, pretended to be only a cat.

Dot, on the awning, pretended to be only a bird.

Mrs. Pell pinned the Closed sign the right way around and unlocked the door for the first customer of a shop that would not close after all.

CHAPTER 6

The Ins

On the first Monday of the new year a man in a stiff brown coat came in with a clipboard.

"Health inspection," he said. "I hear this shop has extra staff."

Mrs. Pell's smile stayed on, but her hands went still in the flour.

Pip, inside the tin, felt his heart tap like a tiny spoon.

The inspector looked under the counter. He looked behind the mixer. He looked at Captain Bean, who yawned in a sunbeam and became, for one important minute, only a cat.

Dot did not land on the awning. She waited on the bakery across the street.

Tim and Tom stood so still they could have been raisins.

The inspector opened the little toaster oven.

It was clean.

He opened the flour tin.

Pip had gone out the back hole two breaths earlier and now sat in the wall, holding his own tail

so it would not shake.

“Mice?” the inspector said.

“Dreams,” Mrs. Pell said. “And a cat. And Friday pie. That is my staff.”

The inspector sniffed the air. Lemon. Sugar. Warm bread. No mess.

He signed the paper.

“Shop passes. Keep it that way.”

When the bell finished jingling, Mrs. Pell leaned her forehead against the flour tin.

“You can come out,” she whispered. “He is gone. The shop is ours. All of ours.”

Pip climbed into the light. Dot landed. Captain Bean pretended he had been brave the whole time. The beetles crawled onto the rim of a saucer like guests who had been invited at last.

Mrs. Pell set down a bottle cap of sugar, a saucer of water, and one midnight button cut into five crumbs.

“This is the deal,” she said. “You bake when I sleep. I bake when you sleep. Nobody talks to the clipboard men. And the Friday pie never goes missing again.”

Pip put his paw on the wood.

“Deal.”

CHAPTER 7

Lights C

Friday came back the way Fridays should: too early, too loud, and full of people who wanted pie.

The boy who had bought the first midnight buttons brought his mother. The bus driver brought two neighbors. Mrs. Pell ran out of forks and did not mind.

At closing she flipped the sign.

Pip stood on the cooling rack with everyone who had ever hidden in the walls.

“Is the story over?” Dot asked.

Pip looked at the clean shop, the signed paper on the nail by the door, the empty pie tin, the cat in the window, the sparrow on the awning, the beetles already arguing about tomorrow’s lemon peel.

“The scary part is over,” he said. “The baking part is just beginning. That is a different kind of ending. The kind that stays.”

Mrs. Pell turned out the front lights and left the oven light on, a small gold square in the dark.

“Good night, night shift.”

“Good night, baker,” Pip said, not too loud.

Captain Bean curled around the warmth like a period at the end of a sentence.

Outside, snow started, soft as sifted flour.

Inside, the Closed sign told the truth for the night, and the shop — mice, bird, cat, beetles, and baker — was open for keeps.

The End